



TRUSTFORCE ADVISORS RESOURCE GUIDE

Trustee Recordkeeping Guide

Organizing Trust Records Like a Professional

Important disclaimer: TrustForce Advisors provides fiduciary support services and does not provide legal advice unless otherwise stated by a licensed attorney. These resources are for general educational and organizational purposes only. Laws, court requirements, fiduciary duties, and reporting rules may vary by state, court, agency, and case type. Always consult the court, your attorney, or a licensed professional regarding your specific situation.

Purpose: This guide helps trustees organize trust documents, financial records, beneficiary communications, and accounting information. Trustees have serious responsibilities. A trustee should keep clear records showing how trust assets were managed, how money was spent, how beneficiaries were informed, and how decisions were made.

Section 1: Core Trustee Duties

Duty of Loyalty

The trustee must act in the best interest of the trust and beneficiaries.

Duty of Prudence

The trustee must manage trust property carefully and responsibly.

Duty to Keep Records

The trustee should maintain accurate records of income, expenses, assets, and distributions.

Duty to Communicate

The trustee may need to provide notices, updates, reports, or accountings to beneficiaries.

Duty to Follow the Trust

The trustee must follow the written terms of the trust.

Section 2: Essential Trust Files

Trust Document File

Keep

- ☐ Original trust agreement
- ☐ Amendments
- ☐ Restatements
- ☐ Trustee acceptance documents
- ☐ Resignation documents
- ☐ Death certificate, if applicable
- ☐ Attorney correspondence
- ☐ Court documents, if any

Banking File

Keep

- ☐ Trust bank account records
- ☐ Monthly statements
- ☐ Deposit records
- ☐ Canceled checks
- ☐ Wire confirmations
- ☐ Bank signature cards
- ☐ Account opening documents

Investment File

Keep

- ☐ Brokerage statements
- ☐ Investment policy notes
- ☐ Advisor communication
- ☐ Dividend records
- ☐ Capital gains reports
- ☐ Buy/sell confirmations

Tax File

Keep

- ☐ EIN confirmation
- ☐ Prior tax returns
- ☐ 1099s
- ☐ K-1s
- ☐ Property tax records
- ☐ CPA correspondence
- ☐ Tax payment confirmations

Beneficiary File

Keep

- ☐ Beneficiary names
- ☐ Addresses
- ☐ Phone numbers
- ☐ Emails
- ☐ Notices sent
- ☐ Distribution requests
- ☐ Distribution records
- ☐ Communication notes

Section 3: Trustee Financial Ledger

Recommended columns

Date	Description	Income	Expense	Distribution	Asset Account	Notes
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Use the ledger to track

- Deposits
- Bills
- Property expenses
- Investment income
- Professional fees
- Beneficiary distributions
- Tax payments

Section 4: Beneficiary Communication Log

Date: _____

Beneficiary: _____

Method: Phone / Email / Mail / In Person

Topic discussed: _____

Documents provided: _____

Follow-up needed: _____

Section 5: Monthly Trustee Review

Each month, complete

- ☐ Review bank statements
- ☐ Review investment statements
- ☐ Save receipts
- ☐ Update ledger
- ☐ Track income
- ☐ Track expenses
- ☐ Document distributions
- ☐ Review unpaid bills
- ☐ File communication records
- ☐ Review pending beneficiary issues

Section 6: Annual Trustee Review

Each year, complete

- ☐ Review trust terms
- ☐ Update asset list
- ☐ Prepare tax documents
- ☐ Review investments
- ☐ Review insurance
- ☐ Review real estate condition
- ☐ Prepare beneficiary summary, if required
- ☐ Meet with CPA or attorney, if needed
- ☐ Confirm distributions were properly documented

Section 7: Sample Filing System

Physical Binder

Folder 1 – Trust Documents

Folder 2 – Banking

Folder 3 – Investments

Folder 4 – Taxes

Folder 5 – Beneficiaries

Folder 6 – Property

Folder 7 – Insurance

Folder 8 – Distributions

Folder 9 – Professional Fees

Folder 10 – Annual Accountings

Digital Folder System

Trust Name

→ 01 Trust Documents

→ 02 Bank Statements

→ 03 Investments

→ 04 Taxes

→ 05 Beneficiaries

→ 06 Property

→ 07 Receipts

→ 08 Distributions

→ 09 Communications

→ 10 Annual Reports

Trustee Mistakes to Avoid

- Treating trust money as personal money
- Making undocumented distributions
- Ignoring beneficiaries
- Failing to file taxes
- Selling assets without review
- Not reading the trust document
- Poor communication
- Missing records
- Delaying required reports

Need Help Managing Fiduciary Responsibilities?

TrustForce Advisors provides professional support for conservators, guardians, trustees, veteran fiduciaries, families and caregivers, attorneys, and professionals.

Schedule a consultation today.

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